

over KDE Plasma in this war of desktop environments. Moreover, other popular desktop environments like Cinnamon, MATE, etc, are forks from GNOME.

Editor wars

Unlike many of the previous rivalries, which were often motivated by commercial reasons, this is a war fought mainly for technical and philosophical reasons. The editor war is also a fiercely ongoing war for becoming the most popular open source text editor. Some of the popular open source text editors include Emacs, Vi, Atom, gedit, KWrite, GNU nano, etc. But the editor war started in the mid-1980s is mainly fought between the supporters of Emacs and Vi. Notice that, nowadays the Vi editor is replaced with the similar yet more powerful Vim editor. The mutual criticism of Emacs and Vim has led to the creation of a lot of jokes. For example, the extensible Vi layer for Emacs (which provides some Vi features in Emacs) is called the 'Evil mode', whereas the supporters of Vim tease the complexity of Emacs by calling it "a great operating system, lacking only a decent editor." In my (biased) opinion, Emacs is like a Swiss army knife - it has so many functionalities that you don't use most of them. Vim is like a machete - just a single lethal blade. Again, my opinion is biased as I prefer Vim, and the one time I used Emacs was to use the org-mode. Soon, I felt that Emacs is too powerful and taxing my poor brain too much. In short, Emacs is complex but powerful, whereas Vim is simple and faster.

Now, let us try to identify the faction having an advantage in the editor war. Results from the Stack Overflow annual developer surveys are a good indicator of the popularity of a tool. The annual surveys from 2016 to 2019 featured a question about popular development environments. Vim was preferred by about 25 per cent of the respondents in these surveys, whereas less than 5 per cent of the respondents

preferred Emacs. This seems like a clear lead. Thus, currently, the future of Vim looks more promising.

Apache OpenOffice vs LibreOffice

If you have decided the Linux distro, the desktop environment, and the text editor for installation in your system, we can move on to the next essential software required, an office suite. Office suites typically include a word processor, spreadsheet program, presentation program, etc. From 2001 to 2011, OpenOffice.org was the most popular open source office suite, and was supported by Sun Microsystems. When the latter was acquired by Oracle Corporation in 2010, many of the contributors to the OpenOffice.org project felt that a fork was necessary.

The turbulent split of OpenOffice.org into LibreOffice and Apache OpenOffice is the reason for the competition for dominance among office suites. Otherwise, the choice would have been obvious. This is also an ongoing war for dominance with no clear winner till date. A point in favour of LibreOffice is that it has more frequent releases when compared with Apache OpenOffice. Another reason for LibreOffice having a slight upper hand over Apache OpenOffice is its look and feel. LibreOffice looks more like Microsoft Office, the very popular proprietary office suite. This might be helpful to a person migrating from Microsoft Office.

Browser wars

The World Wide Web became very popular by the mid-1990s. The first browser war was between Internet Explorer and Netscape Navigator for dominance. In my opinion, this

war ended in a catastrophe as both Netscape Navigator and Internet Explorer failed. Netscape Navigator had its final release in 2008 and Internet Explorer will be discontinued from 2022 onwards. But the browser wars are not over yet. The second browser war is hotting up and is mainly being fought between Chrome, Safari, Edge, and Firefox. Though this is an ongoing war, the current strong contender is Chrome. According to the latest stats by StatCounter (a popular Web traffic analysis website), Chrome has over 60 per cent market share among Web browsers. Safari and Edge are trailing far behind Chrome, and are placed in the second and third positions, respectively. Notice that none of these Web browsers are fully open source. The truly open source Web browser Firefox is placed at the fourth position.

From the above discussion, it can be inferred that frequent forks and competition often negatively affect the adoption of open source software and add to the confusion of a non-technical person planning to switch to Linux. Before concluding, I would like to point out that I mostly use Fedora, KDE Plasma, Vim, LibreOffice, Chrome, etc, and my opinion might be biased. But the point I want to emphasise is that the support for a particular software by the community is often very intense and switching of sides is rare. So if you haven't yet made a decision about the software you want to use, I think this might be a good time to do it. I believe you will be taken more seriously in the world of computing if you are an Ubuntu/GNOME/Vim/LibreOffice/Firefox sort of person than if you are a person indifferent to the software you work with. **END** 🐧

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